

visionsdureel. 2020. "VdR2020 | Carte Blanche | Daphne Xu | A Thousand-Year Stage." YouTube video, 2:39, April 15. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=88tvU_jDdH4.
Zhang, Gary Zhexi. n.d. "Where Next?" *Frieze*. <https://www.frieze.com/article/where-next>.

Sino-no-futurism

GE ZHANG

Only those who were touched by death directly or in their families learned something. But the truth they have arrived at concerns only themselves. It has no future.

—Albert Camus, *The Plague*

Beijing, Shanghai, and Guangzhou won't accept my body, the small country town can't contain my soul.

—Anonymous¹

This essay was written on the quarantined grounds of Wuhan amid a provincial lockdown and is thus inflected with violent affects, as the author was living through sixty-six days of home quarantine. What I term *Sino-no-futurism* is by no means a pessimistic verdict but a plea to decelerate in theorizing Sinofuturity, if such a concept is even on the horizon. This essay views Sinofuturism as a sociotechnological impasse.² While remaining vigilant for new zones of temporal experimentation, this essay chooses not to focus on first-tier cities, manufacturing centers, drones, automation, surveillance, or technonationalism. I am not interested in a critical theory plowing through the categorical "problems" of Sinofuturism but rather in offering a set of provocations based on one particular adaptive mode of living in China—the urban–rural fringe or *chengxiang jiehebu*.³ In Zhao's (2020) theory of *jiehebu* or "fringe" urbanism, the habitual suburban association between suburbia and middle-class life did not really exist in China until more recent redevelopments of the fringe zones into luxury apartments or low-density-living townhouses; instead, *urban–rural fringe* remains the more appropriate term to describe the Chinese suburban in the spatial sense. The urban–rural fringe has always persisted despite being pushed farther as cities expand and therefore remained an enigma for urban planning as its spatiality represented not simply an outmoded filth to be eradicated but also a necessity of one Sinofuturity. My purpose

is to find not an “authentic” Chinese future as much as the concurrent conditions of multiple parallel ongoing Sinofutures, and I do so through an analysis of the quarantined temporality of urban–rural fringe. In the following, I will briefly review the Anglo-iterations of Sinofuturism, then return to the spatiotemporality of the urban–rural fringe as an example, especially in connection to the Wuhan lockdown.

While Sinofuturism, in its emergence as exemplified by a series of essays (Goodman 1998; Land 2014), books (Greenspan 2014; Hui 2016), and videos (Lek 2016), was predominantly an Anglo-centric discourse on cybernetic cultures, digital futures, and sociotechnical speculations, it is recently recaptured by a digital futurity proposed by Chinese state capitalism: self-sufficient state-sponsored digital platforms of cyber-sovereignty (de Seta [2018] aptly terms it “Red Stack”), omnipresent QR codes (specifically their application in digital payment and the “health code” protocols that help facilitate epidemic control), totality of smart city surveillance infrastructure, and so forth. Through a reading of Land’s past essays on the Shanghai Expo and Greenspan’s (2014; Greenspan and Bindselev 2020) perspectives on Shanghai urbanism, I would argue that Sinofuturism in its current English articulation is, as the issue editors already suggest, more of a techno-Orientalist reaction toward the impotence and expiry of the declinist West than an incisive provocation of Chinese futures concretely rooted in the Chinese condition. The disheartened Anglo intellectual looks beyond “the death-grip of an embittered and self-mortifying anti-modernism” (Land 2011) of the apologetic old world and for “zones of experimentation” (Greenspan 2020) in the new world. This starts with an astute critique and an exasperating divorce from the Marxist tradition, but then it falls short in responding to the unrelenting disparity between planned ideals of futurity and their manifestations in an (un)managed disorder in China.

For Sinofuturists, Shanghai is presented as the model city in the spiral of digital urbanism: artificial intelligence in city management, the Pudong skyline, Special Economic Zones, and so forth. Its spectacular retro-futurist revival, initiated by the 2010 World Expo itself, propels it toward the status of World Capital. The central argument is that this revival is textured with a futurity of its own: not linear nor cyclical but a spiral temporality. Seen as fast-forwarding to the past of the 1920s Golden Age, “neomodernity is at once more than modernity and modernity again” (Greenspan 2014, 12). In contrast to Land’s speculative enthusiasm, Yuk Hui’s (2016) assessment of Sinofuturism identifies it as a pathological “modernisation without modernity”: there is nothing new about Sinofuturism as “ultimately, it is only an acceleration of the European modern

project" (297), and a lack of moral cosmotechnics in contemporary China, despite the economic and sociotechnical achievements, can potentially lead to disastrous consequences. In both diagnoses, the singular Sino-future derives from the official vision of modernity, whether in Land's twist of a spiral temporality or Hui's critique of an accelerating society that lacks a moral cosmology. In fact, official narratives affirm both narratives in their seemingly self-contradictory impulses to continuously modernize and (re)establish a traditional cosmological view. To various degrees, both remain ungrounded in already fermenting visions of immiscible futurities elsewhere.

The urban-rural fringe is a temporality of China that is often glossed over by official future-oriented propaganda, but this should not make it seen as somehow more authentic or naturalistic than the city. The fringe is not outright invisible, but it is certainly undesirable, as its clear definition is often obscured. These intermediate contact zones are to be differentiated from *chenzhongcun*, or "urban villages," which were transient, dense, urban overgrowth in and around the city centers to accommodate migrants during the early phase of (re)modernization from the 1990s onward. They were hastily demolished as junk space in the 2010s to pave the way for erections of new urban architectures. In contrast, the urban-rural fringe includes semipermanent settlements that serve an indispensable role between cities and the countryside as "a point of transit and transformation" (Gong 2012). The urban-rural fringe is a "filthy disorder" (Gong 2012) of various settlements: small- to medium-scale factories and workshops; garbage recycling stations; the bastardized residential architecture that arbitrarily and incongruously mixes influences (i.e., stereotypes) from all over the world; main roads as the large trucks pass through with (often unfinished) subsidiary roads connecting the villages; unsanitary restaurants with trashy décor; dodgy home clinics (especially those specializing in abortions); wet markets of fresh produce and various exotic meats, which are chiefly blamed as "sources of hedonistic-cum-pathogenic peril" (Lynteris 2016, 121); and internet cafés filled with underage dropouts who are bored stiff. The fringe also possesses its own digital ecology: almost everyone owns a cheap smartphone with a significantly trimmed Android OS; Kuaishou as the dominant short video/livestreaming app is loaded with fringe residents performing freak bodies, incinerating pranks, quirky comedy skits, and Phoenix Legend-esque sound tracks; apart from Kuaishou, the most common pastime is reading *shuangwen* (literally, "pleasurable text") on smartphone apps.⁴

The urban–rural fringe processes the trash and various material and affective excesses for the cities. It also accommodates the “humiliated people, the peasants [who have] lost their land yet been rejected by the city, the trash collectors” (Gong 2012). The term *piao*, or “float,” was used to accentuate migrant precarity in the first-tier cities.⁵ However, people don’t “float” here at the fringe; instead, people are mostly rejects being sedimented without future hope. It is not sedentariness in the sense of full modernization, as if the society will finally be rid of its “premodern” and transitory deformities. The fringe zone is not a temporary construct. The sociotechnological time of the fringe zone is not simply that of a lag in relation to the city center but almost a parallel singularity. It sinks. It is not an alterity that transcends modernity nor an alienated “dead time” that was fiercely attacked by Situationism but sedentary in the “never-ending everyday” (Thouny 2009, 114). Lawrence Lek (2016) summarizes it well in his video essay: “Sinofuturism does not care about a dramatically better future as long as it survives.” Survival is the true fundamental hard-lined principle—“a futurism of necessity” (Garton 2020). The do-it-so-your-kids-won’t-have-to mentality of postponing the future no longer persists among the younger generation. They put faith in a tiny profit margin and low-affect pleasures they can enjoy now rather than in an uncertain future; there is no sociotechnical morality, no “values,” where there is no time. Gong (2012) considers that the stray dogs omnipresent in the fringe zone and their society formed around human waste present “a portent of our future,” much like the “waste people” on Silicon Isle described in Chen Qiufan’s *Waste Tide*. Unlike for dogs, the waste for people is not simply chemical and neurobiological but also digital: recycled smartphones, desktops cobbled together with salvaged motherboards, “junk” internet literature, and even its own ecology of online subcultures clustered around Kuaishou. It is a futurity arrested in multilayered dissolution and reconfiguration of pollutants and temporality.

The urban–rural fringe produces a no-futurity that symbolizes the “quotidianized apocalypse” (Thouny 2009): “there is no departure, no aim to reach or home to return to” (116). As a contemporary example, my current self-quarantine eerily resonates with the idea of a quotidianized apocalypse of the fringe. Wuhan, the original epicenter of the COVID-19 outbreak, was often disparagingly given the nickname *chaoji da xiancheng* or “supersized county town” for its infamous image of being “unhygienic, disorderly, and dreadful” (*zhangluan cha*).⁶ Wuhan’s spatial texture, unlike the fulfilling aspirations of Shanghai, was accelerating and decelerating at an entirely difference pace. To a large degree, despite being an immense

city in size, Wuhan glorified the aesthetics of the urban–rural fringe as captured in Diao Yinan’s crime thriller *Wild Goose Lake* (2019). In an attempt to elevate itself from the stigma of “supersized county town,” the city hosted international events like the World Military Games 2019, through which the city center was “rejuvenated” and its colonial past (the European concessions much like those in Shanghai) was refurbished and modernized. The expectation was high, much like Shanghai’s World Expo. However, the city only succeeded in garnering international attention due to the current pandemic situation.

During the Wuhan lockdown, time itself is quarantined in a state of continuous waiting with the smartphone being the sole digital companion. Cai Bo (2020) writes on his experience during the lockdown that “time itself is a burning anxiety; my mum used to tell me, days seem to be long but short when they are lived; she complains recently, whatever is plenty, nothing is more plentiful than days.”⁷ During my self-quarantine, linear time or calendar time become irrelevant, and cyclical time also malfunctions as I sleep and wake up during arbitrary hours. A week in, time was spent in between spasms of violent emotions provoked by online videos circulated on WeChat: terror, anxiety, and fury. The quarantine time is “severed forwards” (Cai 2020) as it is torn between stacks of temporalities: the health care system choked, quite literally, by the viral acceleration; desperate and panic-stricken patients waiting eight hours in long queues outside the hospital and risking another round of nosocomial infection; waking up day after day filtering fake news and dubious WeChat screenshots only to find out the “Hope” peddled by propaganda is merely a plastic sham and melts instantly with the flaming anxiety; staying up until midnight to order groceries online before they’re instantly sold out—even the most politically unmotivated realize that poetics of heroism and stories of machinic efficiency (of tracking the infected) merely cover the unknown number of bodies that went into the furnace without any ritual and countless others who live in perpetual anxiety. The imagery of the pandemic is thus “a cyclical plot of meaningless endlessness. . . . [It is] a poetics not of death and resurrection but hollowed out of hope and inhabited by omens and signs of an ‘end indefinitely postponed’” (Gomen, cited in Lynteris 2016, 127).

At the beginning of the lockdown, Žižek (2020) had hoped for the “unintended consequence” of “dead time” self-reflection: being stuck in quarantine at home could potentially force people to be aware of the sedentariness and precarity in “look toward money,” which was how the masses interpreted the official slogan “look to the future” (Cockain 2018, 2). It remains to be seen how much philosophical ruminations are actually

useful during a time such as we are living now. Even the “viral alarm” and public outrage caused by the untimely death of Dr. Li Wenliang did not last long as rage was quickly soaked and dissipated in idleness and lethargy. In this sense, the miserable populace never cared about progress or regression, as it had been already waiting for an “apocalypse that never ceases to come, and pass” (Thouny 2009, 126). Despite the seemingly pessimist undertone, Sino-no-futurism is not a denial of futurism, especially given the simultaneous rise of domestic and international interests and fantasies in constructing a singular Sinofuture but embracing the fermenting grounds of Sinofuturities. As an example, the urban–rural fringe should not be seen as a disintegration or exposé behind the glorious facade of Shanghai but rather as one of the Sinofuturisms we can all, but are too reluctant to, viscerally experience.

Ge Zhang is a postdoctoral fellow at Zhejiang University.

■ NOTES

1. This quote is widely seen on the Chinese internet. It describes a contemporary condition of life where the aspiring migrants in top-tier Chinese cities cannot afford the high housing prices and yet are reluctant to return to their hometowns, where they feel alienated due to sociocultural “backwardness.”

2. This view is heavily influenced by Lauren Berlant’s (2011) work *Cruel Optimism*.

3. It would be naive to juxtapose the urban and the rural, but it’s largely true that until quite recently, rural villages were largely left alone in the developmental discourse as the major cities absorbed the most capable—village life was sapped of its vitality; migration to the cities via cheap labor or university entrance exam was the only upward mobility possible. Gong Jian and Li Jinghu’s art project *Urban Rural Fringe Group* (2012) is a great source of inspiration for this essay. For another example, the animation film *Have a Nice Day* (2017) by Liu Jia also captures the aesthetics of the urban–rural fringe very well (Da 2018).

4. *Shuangwen* is a broad metagenre that may encompass both sci-fi and fantasy. But its primary identifier is that the text usually deploys a male protagonist from the humblest origins defeating the other stereotypically privileged sects of society and gradually reaching the top *without* major setbacks and suffering. The “pleasure” comes from a vicarious triumph over real-world inequalities. *Shuangwen* is immensely popular among the lower socioeconomic classes.

5. Cara Wallis’s (2013) *Technomobility* is a relevant ethnographic

account of this sociotechnical precariousness of the “floating population.”

6. The *xiancheng*, or “county town,” is a different geographical concept from the urban–rural fringe, but the two concepts are almost identical in their imageries of aesthetics and sociality.

7. Chinese translation by the author.

■ WORKS CITED

- Berlant, Laurent. 2011. *Cruel Optimism*. Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press.
- Cai, Bo. 2020. “Wuhan Time Is Torn Forward by Seconds” (in Chinese). <https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/6HLh3N5r-iEiAvNZTPa9TQ>.
- Cockain, Alex. 2018. “Regarding Mr. Wu, a Dragon and Conversations in Traffic: Social Acceleration, Deceleration and Re-acceleration in Shanghai.” *Time and Society* 27, no. 3: 363–83.
- Da, Mengna. 2018. “A Darkly Comic Animated Film Set on China’s Urban-Rural Fringe.” *Hyperallergic*, January 26. <https://hyperallergic.com/423689/have-a-nice-day-jian-liu/>.
- Garton, Vince. 2020. “Sino-No-Futurism (a Comment).” *Cyclonograph II* (blog), April 10. <https://vincentgarton.com/2020/04/10/sino-no-futurism/>.
- Gong, Jian. 2012. “What Is the Urban–Rural Fringe, and Why Is It the Urban–Rural Fringe?” *Leap* (blog), November. <http://www.leapleapleap.com/2012/11/what-is-the-urban-rural-fringe-and-why-is-it-the-urban-rural-fringe/>.
- Goodman, Steve. 1998. “Fei ch’ien Rinse Out: Sino-futurist Under-currency.” *Pli: The Warwick Journal of Philosophy* 7: 155–71.
- Greenspan, Anna. 2014. *Shanghai Future: Modernity Remade*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Greenspan, Anna, and Mikkel Bindslev. 2020. “Zones of Experimentation.” *ΣUM: Journal for Contemporary Art Criticism and Theory* 13: 1873–84.
- Hui, Yuk. 2016. *The Question Concerning Technology in China*. Falmouth, U.K.: Urbanomic Media.
- Land, Nick. 2011. “Re-Animator.” *Old Nick* (blog), August 4. <https://oldnicksite.wordpress.com/2011/08/04/re-animator-part-1/>.
- Land, Nick. 2014. *Shanghai Times*. Urbanatomy Electronic. Ebook.
- Lek, Lawrence. 2016. *Sinofuturism (1839–2046 AD)*. Video art. <https://vimeo.com/179509486>.
- Lynteris, Christos. 2016. “The Prophetic Faculty of Epidemic Photography: Chinese Wet Markets and the Imagination of the Next Pandemic.” *Visual Anthropology* 29, no. 2: 118–32.
- Thouny, Christophe. 2009. “Waiting for the Messiah: The Becoming-

- Myth of Evangelion and Densha otoko." *Mechademia* 4, no. 1: 111–29.
- Wallis, Cara. 2013. *Technomobility in China*. New York: NYU Press.
- Zhao, Yimin. 2020. "‘Fringe’ Urbanism" (in Chinese), UrbanSense. https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/IP5__Ilb1hSdffEr-1BCdA.
- Žižek, Slavoj. 2020. "My Dream of Wuhan." *Welt*, January 22. <https://www.welt.de/kultur/article205630967/Slavoj-Zizek-My-Dream-of-Wuhan.html>.